

Scientists Find New Giant Stick Insects in Australia

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Stick insects look just like twigs. Some of them even fooled scientists!

A team from the University of Sydney studied big stick insects in a group called Anchiale. Scientists thought there were only two kinds in Australia. The team found there are really five. They found two new **species** and brought back a third that had been missed for decades.

The team used **DNA** tests, museum collections, field trips and sightings shared by the public. One well-known stick insect had been given the wrong name for decades. Now it has its own name, Anchiale robusta.

Another new **species**, Anchiale mabiensis, lives in the **endangered** Mabi **rainforest** in Queensland. Its eggs have a special lid. No one had ever seen that in a stick insect before.

"**Taxonomy** is often a bit like detective work," said Dr. Braxton Jones. **Taxonomy** is the science of naming living things.

Word Treasure

species -- A species is one kind of living thing.

DNA -- DNA is the code inside living things that carries instructions for how they grow.

endangered -- Endangered means in danger of disappearing forever.

rainforest -- A rainforest is a thick forest that gets lots of rain.

Taxonomy -- Taxonomy is the science of naming and sorting living things.

Background you need

Stick insects are bugs that hide from hungry animals by looking like twigs.

Scientists give each kind of living thing its own name so they can study it.

Some kinds look almost the same, so scientists use tools like DNA tests to tell them apart.

Break it down

WHO: A team from the University of Sydney, including Dr. Braxton Jones

WHAT: They found that two kinds of giant stick insects are really five

WHERE: Australia, including the Mabi rainforest in Queensland

WHY: Some stick insects look so alike that experts had mixed them up for decades

Why it matters

Even familiar bugs can hold surprises, so scientists keep studying nature to learn what lives around us.

Test what you remember

1. What do stick insects look like?

- ☐ (A) Twigs
- ☐ (B) Rocks
- ☐ (C) Flowers
- ☐ (D) Leaves of grass

2. How many kinds did the team find in the group?

- ☐ (A) Ten
- ☐ (B) Two
- ☐ (C) Five
- ☐ (D) One

3. Which university did the team come from?

- ☐ (A) University of Paris
- ☐ (B) University of Texas
- ☐ (C) University of Tokyo
- ☐ (D) University of Sydney

4. What is special about the eggs of *Anchiale mabiensis*?

- ☐ (A) They are huge
- ☐ (B) They have a special lid
- ☐ (C) They float
- ☐ (D) They are blue

5. Where does *Anchiale mabiensis* live?

- ☐ (A) In the Mabi rainforest in Queensland
- ☐ (B) In a desert
- ☐ (C) In Antarctica
- ☐ (D) Under the sea

6. What is taxonomy?

- ☐ (A) The science of naming living things
- ☐ (B) A kind of tax
- ☐ (C) The study of stars
- ☐ (D) A type of dance

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: B 5: A 6: A

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):